Synthessay

THE NOTEBOOKLM RESEARCH WORKFLOW

From reading list to first draft, without losing your voice.

A repeatable three-stage system for using Google NotebookLM to research faster and think more clearly - **Source, Synthesize, Write**. This page is the whole workflow at a glance; the pages that follow take each stage further, with prompts to copy and worked examples.

01

Source BUILD THE NOTEBOOK

Get every reading into one place before you write a word, so NotebookLM can reason across all of it at once instead of you re-reading everything from scratch.

- Create one notebook per essay - not per module - so sources don't cross-contaminate.
- Upload primary texts and your strongest secondary sources as separate files - lecture slides can be added too, but only if you find them sufficiently useful.
- State the essay question in your prompts as you go - no need to upload it as a source.

Tip - *aim for 7-15 sources. Fewer and the synthesis stage has too little to work with; many more and quality control gets hard.*

02

Synthesize INTERROGATE THE SOURCES

Push past summaries. Interrogate the notebook until it surfaces what each source is actually arguing, and how those arguments collide or reinforce each other.

- Ask NotebookLM to explain each source's core argument and underlying assumptions in detail - not just its topic.
- Map how the sources' arguments and approaches link to one another, and why those links exist.
- Note which academics argue what (and the methods they use), and pull out the case studies and evidence behind each argument.

Tip - *a summary tells you what a source says. Interrogation tells you what it's arguing, and how it argues it.*

03

Write DRAFT IN YOUR OWN VOICE

Turn the argument into a structure you write from - never a paragraph you copy from.

- Ask for an outline only: a thesis and the paragraph-level points that support it, mapped to the sources that back each one.
- Use the notebook's notes panel to make 'active' notes - your own arguments on how you'll use each source, and the links between the arguments and research approaches across different sources.
- Follow each citation back to the original source to check the AI has it right and catch anything useful it left out.

Tip - *refer to what the tool surfaces, but write every sentence in your own words.*

Synthessay teaches research and organisation skills using tools like NotebookLM - not an essay-writing or ghostwriting service. Nothing here should be submitted as your own unassisted work. Always follow your university's policy on AI use.

STAGE 01

Source - build the notebook

Get every reading into one place before you write a word, so NotebookLM can reason across all of it at once instead of you re-reading everything from scratch.

1 Set the notebook up right

- Create one notebook per essay - not per module - so sources don't cross-contaminate.
- Upload primary texts and your strongest secondary sources as separate files - lecture slides can be added too, but only if you find them sufficiently useful.
- Aim for 7-15 sources: fewer and Synthesize has too little to work with, many more and quality control gets hard.
- State the essay question inside your prompts when you interrogate the notebook, rather than uploading it as a source.

2 See it in action

CHOOSING WHAT GOES INTO A NOTEBOOK FOR A QUESTION ON THE CAUSES OF A HISTORICAL EVENT

× WEAK SETUP

The whole module reading list - 20+ items - plus every lecture slide deck, dumped in.

The notebook now answers about the module, not your question. Ask it anything and you get a broad digest with no edge.

✓ FOCUSED SETUP

13 sources chosen for this question - 3 primary, 10 strong secondary - with the question itself stated in each prompt.

Every answer can be measured against the actual question, and a tight, relevant set comes back sharp instead of blurred.

3 Where this stage stalls

Mistake - uploading a whole module's reading list instead of sources chosen for this specific question. Breadth here just dilutes Synthesize later.

Mistake - leaning on lecture slides or summaries instead of the full sources, so the notebook has little of substance to reason across.

Synthessay teaches research and organisation skills using tools like NotebookLM - not an essay-writing or ghostwriting service. Nothing here should be submitted as your own unassisted work. Always follow your university's policy on AI use.

STAGE 02

Synthesize - interrogate the sources

Push past summaries. Interrogate the notebook until it surfaces what each source is actually arguing, and how those arguments collide or reinforce each other.

1 Work the notebook, don't just query it

- Ask NotebookLM to explain each source's core argument and underlying assumptions in detail - not just its topic.
- Map how the sources' arguments and approaches link to one another, and why those links exist.
- Note which academics make which arguments, and the approaches or methods they use - you'll need to show you understand these, and their methods can sharpen your own research.
- Ask it to pull out the case studies and specific evidence each source uses, and how that evidence is deployed to support the argument.

2 Prompts to copy

PROMPT

"Explain the core argument and underlying assumptions of [source] in detail - enough for me to understand it properly, not just a summary of its topic."

PROMPT

"How are the arguments made in [source A] and [source B] linked?"

PROMPT

"Which academic makes each argument, and what method or approach do they use to reach it?"

PROMPT

"Extract the case studies and specific evidence [source] uses, and explain how each is deployed to support its argument."

3 See it in action

TWO WAYS TO ASK ABOUT THE SAME SET OF SOURCES

× WEAK QUESTION

"Summarise what these sources say about [topic]."

You get a flat digest that describes the field. There's nothing in it to take a position on - it reads like a textbook, not an argument.

✓ SHARP QUESTION

"How do the arguments in these sources link to one another - where do they build on, qualify, or cut against each other?"

It maps the relationships between arguments, which is where your own line of reasoning starts to take shape.

4 Where this stage stalls

Mistake - accepting the first answer instead of pushing back with a follow-up. The best material usually comes from the second or third question, not the first.

Mistake - treating a generated study guide or FAQ as your argument. It's a map of the debate, not your position in it.

REMEMBER Hit **Save to note** at the bottom of each useful response so your interrogation is kept in the notebook - not lost when you move to the next prompt.

STAGE 03

Write - draft in your own voice

Turn the argument into a structure you write from - never a paragraph you copy from.

1 Outline, note, draft, verify

- Ask for an outline only: a thesis and the paragraph-level points that support it, mapped to the sources that back each one.
- Use the notebook's notes panel (right-hand side) to make 'active' notes - your own arguments and opinions on how you'll use each source, and the links between the arguments and research approaches across different sources.
- Copy a little key material verbatim into your notes to help you memorise and understand it - but draft from your own arguments, never from generated prose.
- Follow each source citation back to the original: check the AI has it right, and look for relevant or indirectly useful detail it left out.

2 Prompts to copy

PROMPT

"Give me a thesis and the paragraph-level points that support it, mapped to which sources back each one - no full sentences, just the logic."

PROMPT

"Does this outline directly answer the question: [paste your essay question]? Where might a marker say it doesn't?"

3 See it in action

TWO OUTLINES FOR THE SAME ESSAY

× WEAK OUTLINE

Introduction · Background · Analysis · Conclusion.

These are section headers - the shape of any essay. They tell you nothing about what your argument actually says, so you still have to invent every point.

✓ STRONG OUTLINE

Thesis: [position]. Para 1 - Point: [claim]; Evidence: [source / case study]; Explanation: [how it proves the point]. Para 2 - ...

Each paragraph already knows its job - make a point, prove it, explain it - so you write in your own words from a structure that's set.

4 Where this stage stalls

Mistake - drafting straight from the tool's generated prose. Write from your own outline instead: it organises your thinking fast and frees you to write in your own voice, where the freshest, most original ideas often surface mid-sentence.

Mistake - trusting generated quotes without opening the source. Re-check each quote against the original as you read the tool's output - citation drift is the easiest thing to catch and the easiest thing to skip.

REMEMBER Hit **Save to note** at the bottom of each response to keep your outline and active notes in the notebook, ready to write from.

Synthessay teaches research and organisation skills using tools like NotebookLM - not an essay-writing or ghostwriting service. Nothing here should be submitted as your own unassisted work. Always follow your university's policy on AI use.

Quick reference checklist

Keep this page open while you work. Tick through each stage before moving to the next.

Source

- [ ] One notebook per essay, named for the question
- [ ] 7-15 sources: primary texts + strongest secondary reading
- [ ] Essay question stated in your prompts, not uploaded as a source

Synthesize

- [ ] Each source's argument and assumptions stated, not summarised
- [ ] Links between sources' arguments and approaches mapped, with reasons
- [ ] Academics, methods, case studies and evidence noted for each argument

Write

- [ ] Outline checked directly against the essay question
- [ ] Active notes made in the notebook's notes panel, in your own words
- [ ] Citations followed back and checked against the original sources

Synthessay teaches research and organisation skills using tools like NotebookLM - not an essay-writing or ghostwriting service. Nothing here should be submitted as your own unassisted work. Always follow your university's policy on AI use.

THE FREE GUIDE ENDS HERE

Ready to reach the top band?

You now have the research workflow. The premium guide shows you how to turn that research into a **first-class essay** - the structure markers actually reward.

What the premium guide adds

- The Structural Blueprint - reusable frames for the introduction, body paragraph and conclusion.
- Annotated, first-class worked examples - real essay extracts, colour-coded to every part of the frame.
- The moves that lift a top-band essay: defining key terms, the point-evidence-explanation-link spine, the 400-word rule, and more.

Unlock the premium guide

Available at synthessay.com

Synthessay teaches research and organisation skills using tools like NotebookLM - not an essay-writing or ghostwriting service. Nothing here should be submitted as your own unassisted work. Always follow your university's policy on AI use.